BRIEFING · 2026 · SECOND EDITION

Forward Deployed Engineers turn AI pilots into working products

What the role is, where it creates value, what has to change around it, and a pilot to start

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Photo: Ehud Neuhaus paramir / Wikimedia Commons, CC0

WHY NOW

AI companies hire FDEs because most AI pilots stall before production

800%+

Growth in FDE job postings

▲ Jan–Sep 2025

Financial Times data reported by Fast Company

~95%

Generative AI pilots with no measurable P&L impact

— 2025 study

MIT NANDA, The GenAI Divide

2010s

Decade the role was created at Palantir

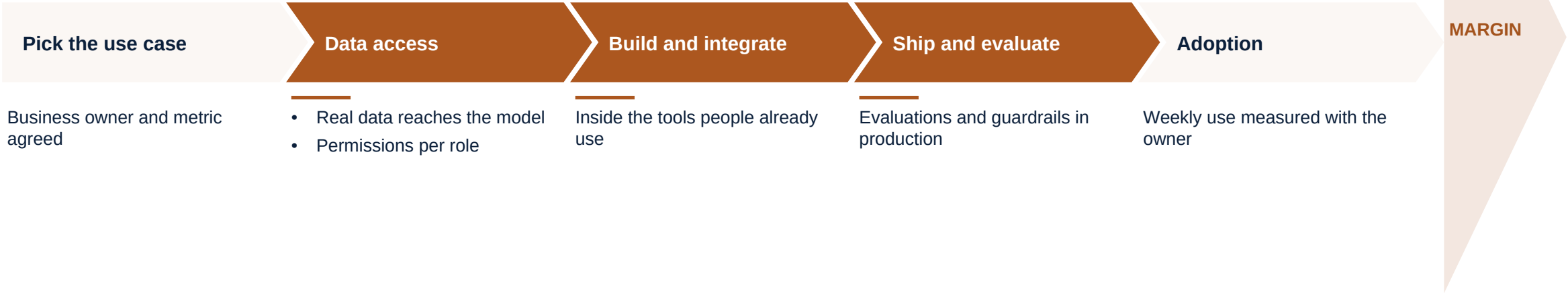
Engineers placed with government and enterprise customers

Source: Postings for this AI job are up 800% (2025) ; The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business 2025 (Aug 2025); What is a Forward Deployed AI Engineer? (2026)

WHERE IT FITS

The FDE owns the middle of the AI value chain, where most pilots stall

MODELS AND PLATFORM	Bought or built once; the same for every use case
SECURITY AND COMPLIANCE	Reviews data access and model behaviour before launch
PEOPLE AND INCENTIVES	Decide whether teams adopt the tool or route around it



Pilots stall in data access, integration and evaluation — the FDE's job

Source: What is a Forward Deployed AI Engineer? (2026); The GenAI Divide: State of AI in Business 2025 (Aug 2025)

WHAT THEY DO

The FDE cycle runs from the user's desk to the core product

Embed	Pick the job	Build	Ship and measure	Feed the product
				
Sit with the people who do the work and map the workflow and its data	Choose the step where AI changes cost, time or quality the most	Connect data, prompts, evaluations and guardrails on the platform	Run it in production and track adoption and the business metric	Turn custom work that repeats into product features

Source: What is a Forward Deployed AI Engineer? (2026)

WHO TO HIRE

The profile combines production engineering, applied AI and customer judgement



Production engineering

Full-stack and data skills; integrates with legacy systems and owns reliability after go-live



Applied AI

Works with model APIs, retrieval, evaluations and guardrails — and knows when not to use a model



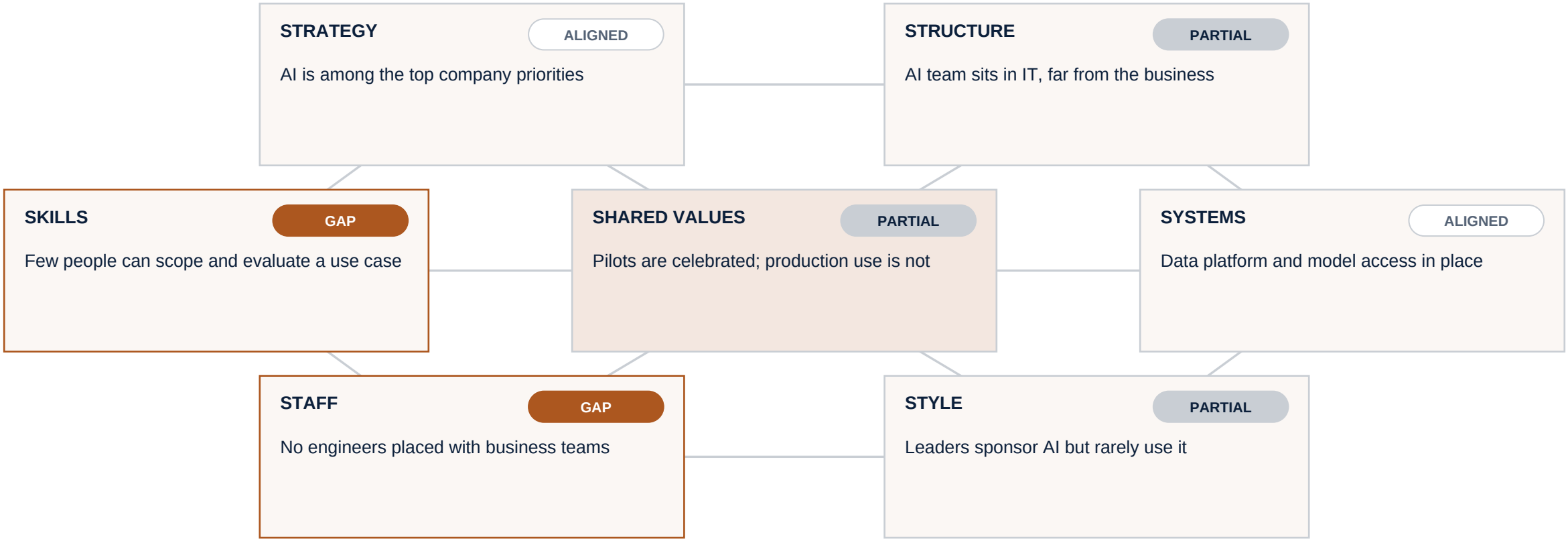
Customer judgement

Scopes problems with domain experts, explains trade-offs and says no to low-value requests

Source: What is a Forward Deployed AI Engineer? (2026)

WHAT HAS TO CHANGE

Strategy and platform are usually ready; staff placement and skills are not



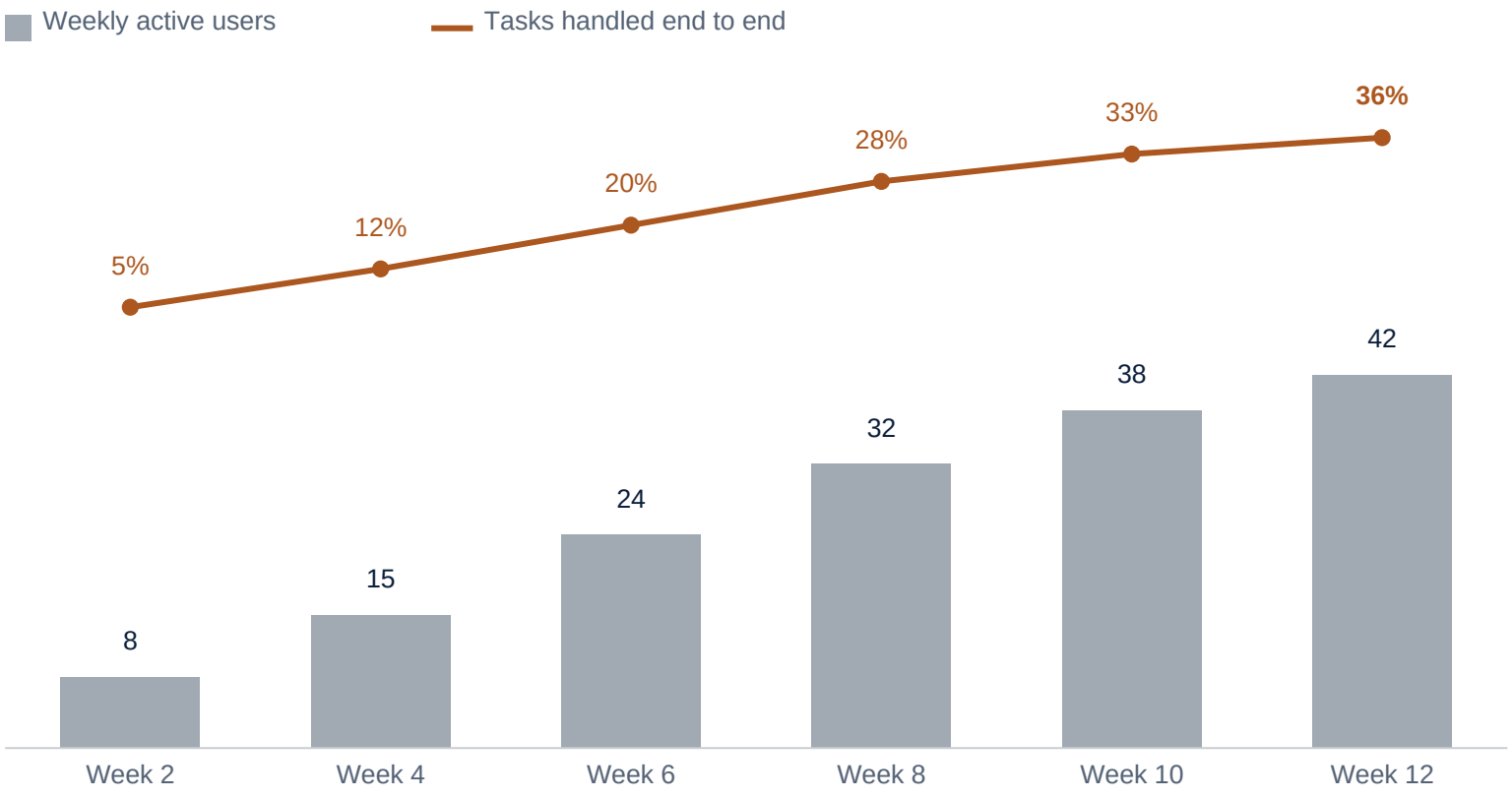
Fix staff and skills first — that is exactly what an FDE pilot tests

Illustrative data. Source: Pilot planning assumptions for a typical enterprise

THE PILOT

The pilot targets 40 weekly users and a third of tasks automated by week 12

Weekly active users, and share of tasks handled end to end, %



Two numbers decide whether to scale

- Users show adoption; automation shows value
- Review both with the business owner every week

Illustrative data. Source: Pilot planning assumptions for a typical enterprise

THE PILOT

A one-quarter pilot costs about $206k, two-thirds of it the engineer

Item	Month 1	Month 2	Month 3	Total
Forward Deployed Engineer	**$45k**	**$45k**	**$45k**	**$135k**
Model and platform usage	$8k	$12k	$15k	$35k
Business owner time	$6k	$6k	$6k	$18k
Evaluation and security review	$10k	$4k	$4k	$18k
Total	$69k	$67k	$70k	$206k

Illustrative data. Source: Pilot planning assumptions for a typical enterprise

WHAT TO DO

Approve one FDE on your highest-value AI workflow for one quarter

DECISION REQUESTED

Approve a one-quarter pilot, about $206k, with one Forward Deployed Engineer on one production workflow

1. **Pick one workflow with a measurable business metric**
   Head of AI · Month 1
2. **Assign or hire one engineer with production and AI experience**
   CTO · Month 1
3. **Embed the engineer with the team that owns the workflow**
   Business owner · Month 1–2
4. **Ship to production and review users and automation weekly**
   FDE · Month 2–3
5. **Decide: scale, turn into product, or stop**
   Leadership team · End of quarter